





Clockwise from left: Anand Kashi by the Ganges, Rishikesh—IHCL SeleQtions; Tiger sightings are practically on loop at Bandhavgarh; Picnic in the wild at Vindhyavilas; The open-fire restaurant Palaash at Tipai Wildlife Luxuries

Ganges, average room rents are ₹38,800, per night, going up to over ₹50,000 in season. "Spiritual tourism is expected to grow at 18–20% CAGR over the next five years," says Samir MC, CEO of Tamara Leisure Experiences which has just launched Raé by Tamara, a brand focussed on spiritual tourism, with the first two hotels opening in the temple towns of Kumbakonam in Tamil Nadu and Guruyavur in Kerala, with properties in Palani, Tirupati, Tiruvannamalai, and Velankanni in the pipeline.

Kapil Chopra, Founder and CEO, The Postcard Hotel that is opening a hotel in Tirupati soon says the affluent Indian pilgrim no longer wants to rough it out. "Tirupati gets one lakh tourists a day," he says. "It's a rich temple, rich people come but there are only 300 branded rooms there," he says pointing out the opportunity. "Luxury and darshan can go hand-in-hand like at the Vatican."

REIMAGINING WILDLIFE TOURISM

From a detox in the midst of nature with Ayurvedic and Tibetan treatments, to immersive experiences that foster a deeper understanding of the forest and local communities, and gourmet dining under star-studded skies, a journey into India's wild is no longer just about animal encounters.

"Wildlife tourism is today attracting a growing base of affluent domestic and international travellers who are willing to spend more for authentic and exclusive experiences," says Datta of HVS Anarock.

Among the luxury forest retreats reshaping the wildlife stay is Outpost 12 (₹40,000 per night) in Tilari village near Kanha National Park, which is led by two naturalists. Beyond the excitement of tiger-spotting, guests slow the pace to fathom the woodlands through expert eyes, spot birds at dusk and dawn, star gaze at night to map the sky and interact with local communities.

Experiences at The Oberoi Vindhyavilas Wildlife Resort in Bandhavgarh, which opened a year ago, lean into guided nature walks, birdwatching, locally-inspired culinary experiences and wellness programmes inspired by the forest. Room rates are upwards of ₹45,500 per night.

A new mantra of luxury wildlife escapes is upscale dining as buffet



"When I was building this restaurant, my partner used to say people will come to Tipai for the food at Palaash and I would laugh. But that is happening now,"
AMNINDER SANDHU, Chef